



» ATHLETICS INTER-STATE CHAMPIONSHIPS



Relentless performance: Sarvesh Kushare, who had already gone past the Asian Games qualification mark of 2.19m, produced his record-breaking clearance at 2.31m on his third attempt. BISWARANJAN ROUT

The high road to history

A decade after beginning his career, Sarvesh Kushare has finally crossed the mark that defines **world-class** high jumpers.

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You know just how special an accomplishment is when it's not just the athlete performing it, but all his opponents who celebrate the moment.

As Sarvesh Kushare leaned back to start his run-up late in the high jump competition at the Inter-State Athletics Championships, the rest of the field at Bhubaneswar's Kalinga Stadium clapped and cheered him on, urging him over the bar.

Just the attempt itself was special. The Indian record, held by Tejaswin Shankar since 2018, stood at 2.29m. Sarvesh had equalled his personal best of 2.28m earlier in the competition. But no Indian had ever set the bar at 2.31m.

At the Kalinga Stadium, Sarvesh

didn't just do that. Running 14 paces in a sharp curve that leaned away from the bar while steadily building horizontal speed, he punched off his right foot and launched himself.

The combination of horizontal speed and the centrifugal force generated by running the curve threw his body — head and shoulders first, then torso and hips and finally calves and heels — smoothly over the horizontal pole.

He bounced off the foam landing platform, punched his fist into the sky and then into the arms of his competitors, who enveloped the new Indian national record holder in bear hugs.

2.31m.

By any stretch of the imagination, it is a remarkable feat. For perspective, there are around 30 more sprinters who have clocked sub-10s in 100m than high jumpers

who have cleared the height Sarvesh managed. It is also a mark that would have won bronze at last year's World Championships.

According to the newly dethroned but still elated national record holder Tejaswin Shankar, simply going past 2.30m is significant.

"The fact that it's a big round number is honestly what makes it so special. In the high jump world, 2.30 is the benchmark for being globally accepted as a world-class high jumper.

"It's a tag you carry proudly. When someone looks at a start list and sees you are a 2.30-plus guy, they take notice worldwide. It's a pretty big deal," he says.

Having chased the mark himself over the course of his career, Tejaswin knows just how hard it is to surpass it.

"I jumped 2.29m in 2018. In the